

Skills Summary

Comparing Three-Digit Numbers

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Two three-digit numbers are never compared digit by digit from the right. Start at the **left**: hundreds first, then tens, then ones. The first place where the digits differ decides everything.

1. Compare with a place-value chart

Rule: write one digit in each box, then walk left to right. Same hundreds? Look at tens. Same tens? Look at ones.

$>$ means “is greater than”; $<$ means “is less than”. The point of the symbol always aims at the smaller number.

Example: Compare 573 and 537.

Step 1. Both numbers have three digits, so the compare starts at the hundreds place — that is the place worth the most.

Step 2. Hundreds: 5 and 5, tied. Tens: 7 against 3, so the first number is ahead and the ones digits are never needed.

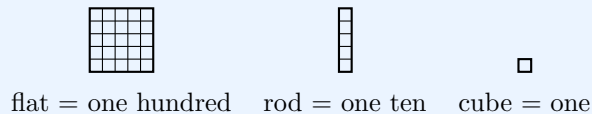
$$573 > 537$$

Try it: Compare 248 and 284.

$$248 < 284$$

2. Compare base-ten blocks

Rule: count flats, then rods, then cubes — the same left-to-right order as the chart.



Example: What number is 4 flats, 1 rod, 6 cubes?

Step 1. Each kind of block names one place, so give each pile its place value instead of counting all the pieces.

Step 2. $4 \times 100 = 400$, $1 \times 10 = 10$, $6 \times 1 = 6$, and $400 + 10 + 6$ fills hundreds, tens, ones.

$$416$$

Try it: What number is 3 flats, 0 rods, 7 cubes?

$$307$$

3. Put three numbers in order

Rule: sort by hundreds first and only break ties with tens, then ones. Writing the three numbers in a chart, one under the other, makes the ties easy to see.

Example: Order 316, 361, 136 from least to greatest.

Step 1. Ordering is just comparing more than once, so sort on the hundreds digit before looking anywhere else.

Step 2. Hundreds are 3, 3, 1, so 136 is smallest. The two with 3 hundreds split on tens: 1 ten against 6 tens.

136, 316, 361

Try it: Order 820, 802, 280 from least to greatest.

check: 280, 802, 820

4. Comparing counts in a story

Rule: pull the two numbers out of the story, compare them the usual way, then answer the question that was asked — “who has more” needs a *name*, not just a symbol.

Example: Room A read 734 pages, Room B read 743 pages. Which room read more?

Step 1. The question is a comparison of two counts, so chart the numbers and compare from the left.

Step 2. Hundreds tie at 7; tens are 3 against 4, so Room B is ahead.

734 < 743, so Room B read more.

Try it: A shop sold 509 apples and 590 pears. Were there fewer apples or fewer pears?

check: 509 < 590, fewer apples